Westbrook School Committee

~ Regular Meeting ~

Date: Wednesday, October 14, 2026
Time: 7:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 117 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1236019921
Packet: https://drive.google.com/file/d/19QuAvillqf5zkaLz_B7lmarS6vYl9SBP/view?usp=drive_link (Google Drive, via westbrookschools.org)

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *All seven regular members were present; both student representatives attended, including new member Skylar Stevenson. The meeting addressed a serious social media incident involving two students, at length and with unified committee condemnation, alongside a major energy efficiency financing item. Every vote passed unanimously. Summarization necessarily condenses and selects; for complete context, nuance, and anything not covered, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

Unofficial summary. *This is produced by Westbrook Currents, an independent site — not the City of Westbrook — and may contain mistakes. For the official record, see the City's approved minutes and the meeting video.*

Communications: Special Education Staffing

Special Education Ed Tech Shortage [2:58]

Discussion Summary

In response to a question from the Chair, Dr. Lancia reported the district has lost three special education ed techs in the past month (two from the middle school) and currently has 16 special-education ed tech openings — more than 10% of the roughly 60 such positions districtwide, many vacant since the start of the school year. Coverage is being managed through substitutes and reassignment; active recruiting includes a recent USM job fair and social media outreach.

Key Decisions

Action Items

None.

Superintendent's Report: The Social Media Incident

Background & the District's Response [7:48]

Discussion Summary

Dr. Lancia read a prepared statement responding to an anonymous social media page that, the prior week, used a false narrative about transgender athletes to attack two Westbrook High School student athletes by name and photograph. He reaffirmed the district's equity and inclusion commitments, citing the district's statement of equity and opportunity and policies AC and ACAA (referencing Title IX and the Maine Human

Rights Act).

Key Decisions

Action Items
None.

> *“The recent social media posts targeting our student athletes are unacceptable. Singling out children and using their photographs to advance a political agenda is wrong … Adults have a responsibility to exercise integrity and discretion … Let kids be kids.”*

— Mayor David Morse [12:51]

> *“Two female Westbrook High School athletes experienced a hateful online attack by adults … we are also encouraged by our community's response stating loudly that Westbrook will not stand for this type of hate. All students deserve to feel safe and welcome here.”*

— State Representatives Susan Salisbury, Drew Gattine, and Morgan Rielly (names as best captured from the audio) [12:51]

Chair's Remarks [12:51]

Discussion Summary
Chair Mancuso addressed a circulating rumor that a committee member had been involved in spreading the false information, stating plainly she was confident no board member had done so, and that scapegoating school staff or leadership “is just further cowardice.” She noted the posts came down within hours once their inaccuracy became clear, without any retraction or apology from the original source. Erin Cavallaro echoed the sentiment, emphasizing that community standards are defined “by the choices that our neighbors make when those principles are tested.” No vote or formal action was associated with this discussion.

Key Decisions

Action Items
None.

Student Representative Report

Highlights & a Technology Concern [20:01]

Discussion Summary
Westbrook Middle School's “Fewer Than Two” attendance campaign and the Maine Celtics Playbook anti-discrimination program; WRVC's new partnership sending Tech 1 students to Canal School's pre-K/kindergarten classrooms; Westbrook High School's college night, upcoming PSATs, a fall concert October 28, and the first quarter closing October 30.

Students raised a concern about overly aggressive content filtering on school laptops (e.g., a band-instrument “fingering chart” search blocked for a flagged word; Google Translate/Maps inaccessible). Dr. Lancia confirmed a technology task force examining usage and security is being convened with student voice included, and directed students to route specific issues through Principal Garrett to the technology department.

Key Decisions

Action Items

None.

Subcommittee Reports

Educational Programs — Katy Rice [27:15]

Discussion Summary

Discussed the district's strategic plan themes for the year (equity and opportunity; teaching and learning; social-emotional learning; communication and collaboration), with each school finalizing its own goals. Pre-K enrollment is at 82 students across six sections plus one self-contained classroom; a new “Advanced Physical Fitness” elective launches next semester for grades 10–12.

In discussion, Cavallaro requested a fuller presentation on each school's “success/improvement plans” to the full committee in November, tied to upcoming budget-season conversations. Dr. Lancia separately reported the Great Schools Partnership special education program review has been delayed slightly but will proceed this fall, with a goal of actionable findings ready for budget deliberations.

Key Decisions

Action Items

None.

Facilities (Reported in Brooke Reed's Place) [37:43]

Discussion Summary

Director of Facilities Vicky Hebert toured the committee through Canal School's new bathrooms and pre-K rooms (state-funded startup furniture for five rooms); the existing playground was flagged as unsuitable for four-year-olds and will need review.

Key Decisions

Action Items

None.

Finance — Noreen Poitras [39:00]

Discussion Summary

Revenue adjustments: WRVC down roughly $213,388 (a technical program not running this year), pre-K up roughly $145,675 (enrollment growth), and the ED-279 state subsidy line up roughly $204,750, for a net General Purpose Aid (GPA) gain of roughly $137,038. Total major-capital debt service stands at about $4.11 million. Poitras raised concern that the contingency fund — roughly $239,000 — is “extremely tight” this early in the fiscal year.

In discussion, the Chair questioned the plan to cover a roughly $94,000 overage on the Congin/Canal bathroom and vestibule remodel using increased General Purpose Aid rather than contingency, noting GPA increased specifically from pre-K and disadvantaged-student funding formulas. District staff responded that GPA is legally unearmarked and that funding facility infrastructure is a legitimate use. Cavallaro asked that contingency's importance be remembered during spring budget cuts.

Key Decisions

Action Items

None.

Policy — Erin Cavallaro [54:39]

Discussion Summary

Policy EEA (transportation) was revisited after community feedback; the committee decided not to amend it. A required mandated-reporting policy update is still in progress (the Maine School Management Association's model language was found inadequate). An AED (automated external defibrillator) policy also needs updating for new state requirements (compliance deadline end of next calendar year). A new policy on immigration enforcement on school property, required by state law by the end of this calendar year, will come to the committee for its two required readings in November and December.

Key Decisions

Action Items

None.

Old Business

11.1 — Bus Lease Purchase, Final Approval [57:53]

Discussion Summary

Key Decisions

✓ Approved unanimously by roll call (including both students' advisory votes), moved by Katy Rice, seconded by Erin Cavallaro.

Action Items

None.

New Business

12.1 — Administrator/Teacher Nominations

Discussion Summary

None this meeting.

Key Decisions

Action Items

None.

12.2 — Adjourn Into Executive Session — Contract Negotiations [59:25]

Discussion Summary

Pursuant to 1 M.R.S.A. §405(6)(D). The committee returned to open session roughly 29 minutes later.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved unanimously by roll call, moved by Erin Cavallaro, seconded by Allison Brunette.

Action Items

None.

12.4 — Ratify the 2026–2029 Support Staff Collective Bargaining Agreement, First and Final Approval (Amended on the Floor) [01:28:59]

Discussion Summary
The Chair thanked the support staff negotiating team, Westbrook Education Association president Sue Lombardo, chief negotiator Noreen Poitras, and negotiating-team members Katy Rice and Andrea Mancuso.

Key Decisions
✓ Approved unanimously by roll call (including student advisory votes), moved by Erin Cavallaro, seconded by Noreen Poitras.

Action Items
None.

12.5 — Emergency Expenditure for Fire Alarm Phase 1 Replacement, First Approval [01:31:09]

Discussion Summary
Facilities Director Tony Lombardo explained the combined Westbrook High School/WRVC fire alarm system was installed in 1988 (38 years old) and has triggered six false alarms this summer alone, including one requiring an overnight fire watch. The district is replacing the system in phases with a compatible Siemens system, starting with the main control panel and the most problem-prone device loop, at a cost of $38,650, funded from the already-tight contingency line.

Because the next phase of work won't begin until parts arrive in late November, the committee scheduled this for final approval the following month rather than making it first-and-final, per the required 72-hour gap between first and final votes.

Key Decisions
✓ Approved unanimously by roll call (first approval only), moved by Allison Brunette, seconded by Noreen Poitras.

Action Items
None.

12.6 — Annual School Emergency Plan, First and Final Approval [01:37:35]

Discussion Summary
Dr. Lancia explained the plan (covering general, technology/cyber, and athletics emergencies) is reviewed every fall; this year's changes were largely names and dates. He thanked Allison Brunette for reviewing it closely on the committee's behalf. Erin Cavallaro shared, as a parent, that reading the full plan and witnessing a recent lockdown drill at Sacarappa left her reassured by its thoroughness.

Key Decisions
✓ Approved unanimously by roll call, moved by Erin Cavallaro, seconded by Katy Rice.

Action Items
None.

12.7 — Energy Efficiency Phase 2 (Engineering Study Authorization With Siemens), First Approval [01:42:12]

Discussion Summary
This was the meeting's most heavily scrutinized item, running nearly 25 minutes of Q&A. What's being approved is authorization for Siemens to conduct an in-depth engineering study identifying the next phase of building efficiency projects (building controls, energy-recovery air exchangers) — not a construction contract

itself. Phase 1 (LED lighting/HVAC/building envelope) is complete; Phase 2 (solar generation) is now online and tracking near or ahead of budget-neutral, with two schools currently running an electricity credit surplus.

Financial structure: a 2023 agreement carried an approximately $88,292 fee exposure if the district didn't proceed with enough proposed projects; this new agreement carries a similar exposure of roughly $137,000–$147,000, rolled into total project costs if the district proceeds. Per state statute, Siemens must demonstrate the projects will be budget-neutral or better over their lifetime, with a performance guarantee.

Chair Mancuso pressed for the actual draft Project Development Agreement (the packet contained only the older one), and confirmed the district's legal counsel, Drummond Woodsum, has not yet reviewed the new agreement — review is planned between the required readings, after a prior version required counsel to strike objectionable liability-limitation clauses. She confirmed no contract will be signed before a second, final committee vote.

Anticipated project scope is roughly $3–6 million and would likely require bonding. Dr. Flynn Ross highlighted the scale of potential financial upside: roughly $492,000 in avoided energy costs, $58,000 in solar profit, a potential $768,547 solar investment tax credit, roughly $50,000 in solar renewable-energy-credit sales, and a further $500,000–$1 million in potential Efficiency Maine rebates. Erin Cavallaro, who attended a Siemens presentation at Canal, strongly endorsed the project, noting urgency tied to the November 3 election's potential effect on Efficiency Maine funding, and asked for a shorter presentation to the full committee before the final vote. Noreen Poitras asked whether a future full remodel of Westbrook High School might render this work redundant; staff clarified the two are separate projects, though a future remodel would likely align with any new energy equipment installed now.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved unanimously by roll call (first approval only; a fuller presentation and final vote are expected in November), moved by Noreen Poitras, seconded by Katy Rice.

Action Items

None.

12.8 — Authorize the Committee's Delegate to the Maine School Boards Association (MSBA) Delegate Assembly, First and Final Approval [02:07:47]

Discussion Summary

Erin Cavallaro, the committee's delegate, previewed the resolutions up for a vote at the October 24 assembly, noting the immigration-enforcement-related resolutions were likely to generate the most discussion. She highlighted one new proposed resolution — that school boards should include at least one voting student member — as something Westbrook already does with two.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved unanimously by roll call, moved by Dr. Flynn Ross, seconded by Erin Cavallaro.

Action Items

None.

Important Dates

Upcoming Meetings [02:11:36]

Discussion Summary

October 21, 5:00 PM: Facilities Committee (Westbrook High School). October 28, 5:00 PM: Policy Committee (Central Office). November 4, 5:00 PM: Finance Committee (Central Office). November 11: no school (Veterans Day). November 18, 5:00 PM: Educational Programs Committee (Central Office), followed by the November regular School Committee meeting at 7:00 PM (Room 114). November 25: no school (compensatory day); Policy Committee, 5:00 PM (Central Office). November 26–27: no school (Thanksgiving).

Key Decisions

Action Items

None.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was transcribed with AI-assisted speech-to-text and speaker identification. This process cross-checked names against the official School Committee roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the Chair) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. No agenda or back-up packet was published for this meeting (checked westbrookschools.org, 2026-10-24); this summary is drawn from the video/transcript alone. Review tier: Not reviewed.

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